SECTION 2

What Can Be Taken?

Three cases, from 1876 to today

Most theft is easy to recognise. Something leaves its owner without permission, and the owner no longer has it. The three cases here are harder. In each, something small moved: seeds from a forest, blood from a village, photos from the internet. Yet it is hard to say what the owner lost.

Brazil kept its rubber trees. The donors gave their blood willingly. The original photos stayed online.

What changed was what each thing became: plantations on another continent, data for studies the donors say they never agreed to, a search engine for faces. Those who call these cases theft point to what the thing became, not only to what moved.

The cases span 150 years, from the age of empire to the age of the internet. Each panel sets out what happened, who calls it theft and why, and how the other side answers.

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